Direct object control in Russian gerundives: an experimental study

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The talk presents an experiment investigating the properties of direct objects that influence the availability of non-obligatory control in Russian gerundive clauses. According to the Academic Grammar of Russian [RAG-80], control in gerundive clauses is attested only with either the nominative subject of the local matrix clause or by the PRO of the embedded infinitive clause. However, it has been noted [Glovinskaya 1996] and confirmed by corpus-based studies [Zhukova et al. 2020] that different non-canonical types of the control of gerundives are present, though still extremely marginal. These include control by direct objects (1) and indirect objects, non-nominative subjects (2) and possessors, as well as the absence of an overt controller.

(1) [***PRO***$_i$ *Buduči* *uže* *vpolne* *zrelym* *čelovekom,*]
be.GER already quite mature man.INS
menja$_i$ *vymanil* *Mixalkov* *igrat'* *Oblomova*
1SG.ACC lure.PST M. play.INF O.ACC
'While being a quite mature man, Mikhalkov made me play Oblomov.'
[Glovinskaya 1996]

(2) [***PRO***$_i$ *sidja* *na* *lekcii,*]
sit.GER.IPFV on lecture.LOC
emu$_i$ *xočetsja* *čaju.*
3SG.M.DAT want.PRS tea.GEN
'While attending the lecture, he wants to drink some tea.' [Zhukova et al. 2020]

These non-canonical types of control are classified as non-obligatory control according to the definition [Landau 2024] since the controller need not be a co-dependent of the non-finite clause. Canonical cases of gerundive control are examples of obligatory control. Such duality is captured by the Two-Tiered Theory (TTC) of adjunct control [Landau 2021]. [Landau 2021] suggests that there are two types of adjuncts: those that always fall under obligatory control (strict OC adjuncts) and those that alternate between obligatory and non-obligatory control (alternating OC/NOC adjuncts). I suggest that Russian gerundive clauses belong to the class of alternating OC/NOC adjuncts. Non-canonical cases of control have non-arguments as controllers, which is a diagnostic for NOC, and the sentences in which the controller is inanimate demonstrate OC. I will demonstrate that Russian gerundives also pass the remaining diagnostics for the OC/NOC distinction. The possibility of alternation is made possible by the high position of attachment of gerundives, which is, at least sometimes, a TP node [Goncharov 2016].

When syntactic and semantic conditions are satisfied for non-obligatory control in the way proposed by TTC, the question is how the controller is defined. [Landau 2021] provides a generalisation: a DP may control PRO iff a) DP is [+top] or a logophoric centre; b) as a rule, if DP is [+top], it is also [+human]. This study is focused on the possibility of control by direct object in Russian gerundives, so I propose two hypotheses. The first one comes from Landau's generalisation: topical direct objects are more acceptable controllers of gerundives than non-topical ones. The second one is based on the suggestion that potential logophoric status of the DP impacts the availability of control by a direct object: I assume that experiencers are more acceptable controllers than patients since the former but not the latter ones might potentially have a mental perspective.

305 native speakers of Russian participated in the experiment and the responses of 288 of them were analysed (mean age = 39.86, standard deviation = 10.39). The experiment was

conducted via the PCIbex Farm platform [Zehr, Schwarz 2018] with 2 × 2 design. The first factor is (non-)topicality that was manipulated via word order under the assumption that participants read sentences with default intonation [Petelin 2021], which provides the object's topicality in Russian. The second factor is object theta role with levels of experiencer and patient that was manipulated via the matrix predicate (3). In all sentences the object was marked with accusative case. The forced choice paradigm was applied; previous experiments [Zhukova et al. 2020] have demonstrated that despite being present in corpora, sentences with non-canonical control still receive relatively low acceptability ratings from respondents in the grammaticality judgement task. However, it has been found that sentences with non-canonical gerundive control with a preposed gerundive clause are more acceptable than those with a postposed gerundive clause [Zhukova et al. 2020], which is why in the present experiment gerundive clauses are preposed. Participants read the sentences with gerundive clauses in a self-paced manner and after that were asked who — subject or object — carried out the action expressed in the gerundive clause. There were 16 sets of stimuli in four conditions each distributed among four experimental lists, see (3) for an example of a set.

(3) **Non-topical patient**:
Pokinuv samolet, Leša uvidel Anju.
leave.GER.PFV plane L. see.PST A.ACC
'Having left the plane, Lesha saw Anya.'
Topical patient: *Pokinuv samolet, Anju uvidel Leša.*
Non-topical experiencer:
Pokinuv samolet, Leša uspokoil Anju.
leave.GER.PFV plane L. calm.PST A.ACC
'Having left the plane, Lesha calmed Anya.'
Topical experiencer: *Pokinuv samolet, Anju uspokoil Leša.*

Distribution of answers is illustrated in Fig. 1. Logistic regression was applied to the data. The results revealed that topical objects are significantly more likely to be chosen as controllers than non-topical ones (*Odds Ratios* 51.16, $p < 0.001$). The significance of theta role was not confirmed, as well as the significance of interaction between topicality and theta role; however, stable numerical preference for experiencer objects over patient ones was observed (Fig. 2). This suggests that the effect of the theta role, if present, is very weak. However, it may be more prominent in other constructions, such as ones with dative objects. In general, the study has shown the significance of topicality for NOC in Russian gerundives and provides support for several aspects of TTC on Russian data. Further research is needed to define the limits of NOC in Russian: what role the status of the logophoric centre plays and whether topicality and logophoricity have truly equal impact on the acceptability of NOC.

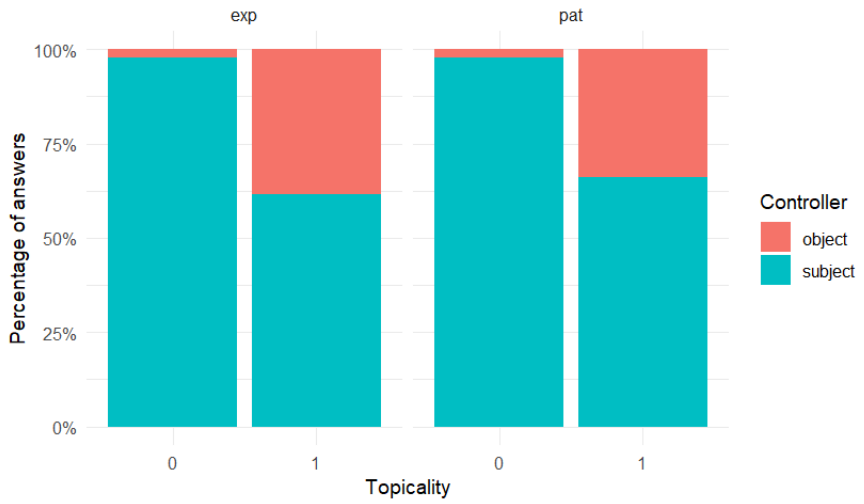


Fig. 1. Distribution of answers among conditions (percentages)[1]

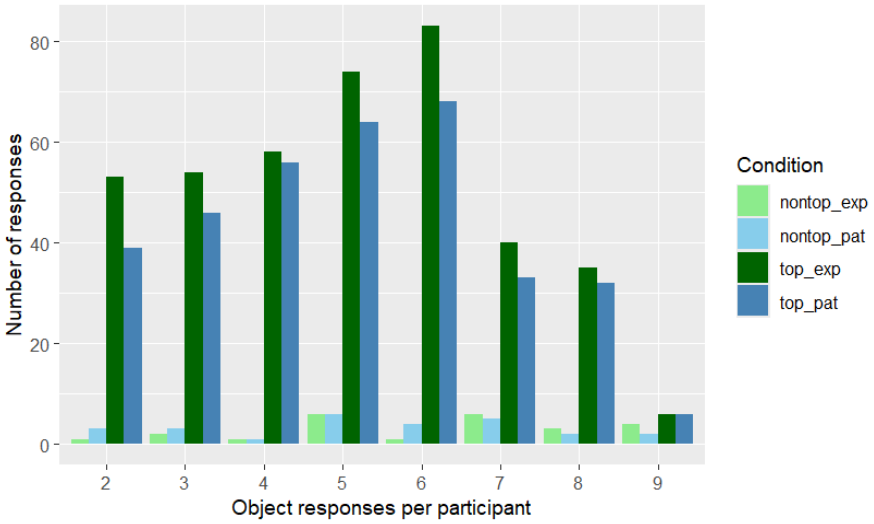


Fig. 2. Distribution of object responses among conditions

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[1] "1" for topicality represents topical condition, and "0" represents non-topical one.

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